

These are simple cases of disagreement. Many people have the intuition that, in cases like these, disagreement should lead us to revise our beliefs.

Whenever someone has as many of the qualities which are relevant to correctly answering some question as you do, we will say that that person is your **epistemic peer**.

Intuitively, the idea is that your epistemic peer is just as likely to give the correct answer to some question as you are. So, if an epistemic peer disagrees with you, you should reduce your confidence in your own belief.

Of course, we are making some background assumptions about these cases. For example, in the case of the horse race we are assuming that the other person has as good of eyesight as you do. And in the splitting the bill case we are assuming that your friends are not terrible at math.

Exactly how much should you reduce your confidence?

The natural answer to this question starts with the fact that, in ordinary life, we don't just believe or disbelieve things; we also take them to have a certain probability of being true.

The probability that you take P to have is called your credence in P . Credence can be expressed as a percentage, or as a number between 0 and 1 (1 means that you are sure that P is true, 0 that you are sure that P is false).

Probability-splitting

If you assign P credence N , and come across an epistemic peer who assigns P credence M , then you should change your credence in P to the average of N and M .

Suppose that both you and your friend have credence of 0.9 in your initial views about the winner of the horse race. This rule says that, on learning of your disagreement, you should both adjust your credence to 0.5.

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This rule also seems to say the right thing about cases in which you meet a large

number of peer-reviewed papers who disagree with you.

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